POEM: EXTRACT FROM THE PREDULDE

One summer evening (led by her) I found
A little boat tied to a willow tree
Within a rocky cave, its usual home.
Straight I unloosed her chain, and stepping in
Pushed from the shore. It was an act of stealth
And troubled pleasure, nor without the voice
Of mountain-echoes did my boat move on;
Leaving behind her still, on either side,
Small circles glittering idly in the moon,
Until they melted all into one track
Of sparkling light. But now, like one who rows,
Proud of his skill, to reach a chosen point
With an unswerving line, I fixed my view
Upon the summit of a craggy ridge,
The horizon's utmost boundary; far above
Was nothing but the stars and the grey sky.
She was an elfin pinnace; lustily
I dipped my oars into the silent lake,
And, as I rose upon the stroke, my boat
Went heaving through the water like a swan;
When, from behind that craggy steep till then
The horizon's bound, a huge peak, black and huge,
As if with voluntary power instinct,
Upreared its head. I struck and struck again
And growing still in stature the grim shape
Towered up between me and the stars, and still,
For so it seemed, with purpose of its own
And measured motion like a living thing,
Strode after me. With trembling oars I turned,
And through the silent water stole my way
Back to the covert of the willow tree;
There in her mooring-place I left my bark,–
And through the meadows homeward went, in grave
And serious mood; but after I had seen
That spectacle, for many days, my brain
Worked with a dim and undetermined sense
Of unknown modes of being; o'er my thoughts
There hung a darkness, call it solitude
Or blank desertion. No familiar shapes
Remained, no pleasant images of trees,
Of sea or sky, no colours of green fields;
But huge and mighty forms, that do not live
Like living men, moved slowly through the mind
By day, and were a trouble to my dreams.

William Wordsworth

*The boat is a **metaphor** of man's influence, still anchored by the tree representing nature.*

Loosening the chain and pushing from shore represents the poet as mankind moving to stand on its own two feet.

*Wordsworth creates an idyllic and peaceful scene with **language semantically** peaceful.*

The mood changed with the craggy ridge and horizons boundary represents nature, limiting the progress of the poet.

*The term 'elfin pinnace' could be translated as 'fairy boat', a **metaphor** for the now heated mood of the poet. Elves were often viewed as sexual and lustful.*

*The **simile** reminds us that anything man tries to produce is merely imitating (copying) nature which does it better.*

*The Horizon marks the shift in tone, the language becomes darker and dangerous. The peak, mountain, is **personified** "with purpose of its own", nature shown as aggressive.*

*Use of 'trembling' **connotes** the fear and vulnerability of the poet, he is shown like a wounded animal, hiding away.*

*Meadows, usually peaceful and joyful and **juxtaposed** to the 'grave and serious mood'.*

*The darkness hanging over him represents his change to a darker mood at the end of the journey. The words all carry a dark and sinister tone, more morbid and melancholy. He is reflecting on the **conflict** in his mind of the juxtaposed peaceful side of nature and the harsh extremes it also contains "big and mighty forms".*

*The poem changes from **Euphony** (pleasant sounding words) to a **Cacophony** (harsh and rough sounding words.)*

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-Look up the romantic poets, what was their influence.

-Look at the rest of the poem (or a summary) see how this fits into the work as a whole.

Context:

William Wordsworth was a romantic poet, we don't mean he wrote love poems, but he wrote poems about the world we live in which challenged people and the way they thought at the time. During this time 'epic' poems of large length were common, as were poems which looked at the world and man's place within it. This extract is from a much larger poem, it looks at the spiritual and moral development of a man growing up.

Themes:

The poem is quite hard to relate to conflict and power. However there is a sense of conflict between man and nature where nature is eventually shown to be more powerful in the end.

Boating along:

During the poem the setting is of a journey in a boat. The journey represents a more spiritual journey and it becomes more rough and hostile along the way. At first, nature is shown at peace with the poet, later as it gets darker and he tries to reach the horizon it becomes harsh and predatory, putting man back in his place.

Structure: Written as part of a much larger piece. This section is 44 lines in blank verse (no real structure). The work is in iambic pentameter to give it a consistent pace.

As the poem progresses the journey the poet is on becomes rougher and words like 'and' are repeated to give it a breathless pace and feel.

Mountain:

"a huge peak, black and huge, As if with voluntary power instinct, Upreared its head." The mountain is shown in the poem like a great angry entity and represents the full might and power of nature. It seems to take offense at the poet going too far or too 'lustily'. You could imagine it like a game of 'chicken' where the poet is rowing toward the mountain, the closer he gets the more menacing it appears before he backs away.

Higher Marks

-The poem symbolically uses the journey on the river to mirror the poets own spiritual journey of reflection.

-The poet is structured to show the contrast of the serene and peaceful start where we works with nature, to the dark and disturbing battle with nature shown from when he tries to control his journey through rowing.

-The conflict between man and nature is caused by mans attempt to manipulate nature, nature still contains a power and majesty beyond mankind's ability to command.

Lower Marks

-The poem is about a journey on the river.

-The poet is at peace but by the end of the journey he becomes troubled.

-The journey helps show how mankind is a part of nature but does not rule over it.

Space for your notes: